



HackIllinois 2026 HackVoyager Guide

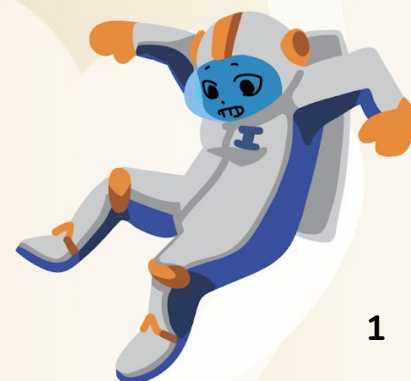
Welcome!

Thank you for participating in HackIllinois 2026! Before you launch into your cosmic journey, review this HackVoyager's Guide to Mission Control to help you navigate uncharted galaxies, conquer challenges, and chart a course toward innovation and glory.

The guide is meant to serve as a comprehensive overview of what to expect at the HackVoyager Project Showcase and Pitch. It will cover the vital information you need to know for the event.

We hope this guide answers any questions you might have, but feel free to send a message on Discord or send us an email at contact@hackillinois.org if you have any questions!

Note that all times on this document are in CST (GMT - 6:00).



Project Requirements and Submission

Submitting Your Project

Use the [HackIllinois Devpost](#) to submit your project!

Submission Checklist

To qualify for submissions, you will need to meet these criteria:

- Everyone on your team **must be registered, RSVPed, and checked in for HackIllinois.**
- You must submit your project before the submission deadline (**Sunday, March 1st at 6:00 AM CST**).
 - We recommend submitting earlier so that you don't miss the deadline. Late submissions will not be accepted.
- You must be registered with only **one team**.
- Your team must have **four members or less**.
- Your project must have been created **during the 36 hours of the event**.
- Your project must have only been submitted to HackIllinois 2026.
- **At least one team member** must be physically present at the **Project Showcase** to demo the project.
- **All team members** must be physically present for the **HackVoyagers Pitch** presentation unless prior approval has been granted via email.
- Your project submission on Devpost must contain a public GitHub Repository, a video demo or presentation video (made unlisted or public) that is no longer than 3 minutes, and a description addressing the respective track.

Failure to adhere to these may result in disqualification; final discretion lies with HackIllinois staff. If you are unsure about anything related to Devpost Project Submission, please contact us through contact@hackillinois.org or the Help Desk role on Discord!

Judging Overview

Track & Path Judging

You must be present at the Project Showcase, a science fair-type project showcase, to be eligible for the Best Voyager Hack. The HackVoyagers Project Showcase will take place at **Room 2405**.

Inspired by the hit TV series Shark Tank, the HackVoyagers Pitch is focused on promoting entrepreneurship in technology by having top 7 HackVoyager teams pitch their project to a panel of judges. The HackVoyagers Pitch will take place at **Room 0216**. It will be streamed to watch on [YouTube](#).

Note: All group members must be HackVoyagers for the project to qualify for the HackVoyagers Pitch.

Structure

6:00 AM: Devpost Submission – After submitting your Devpost at 6:00 AM, please **check your email and Discord regularly**, as communication regarding your table allocation and other instructions will be sent through the channels.

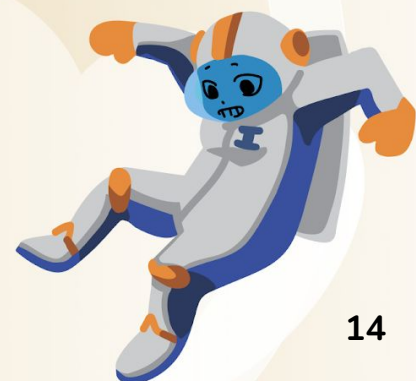
9:00 AM – 11:30 AM: Project Showcase

During the Project Showcase, teams will present their project and answer any brief questions judges may have for a maximum of 5 minutes. **At least one team member must be physically present** to demo the project.

12:00 PM - 1:30 PM: HackVoyagers Pitch (Sponsored by Fulcrum)

All team members must be physically present for the HackVoyagers Pitch presentation unless prior approval has been granted.

2:00 PM - 3:00 PM: Closing Ceremony (Awards)



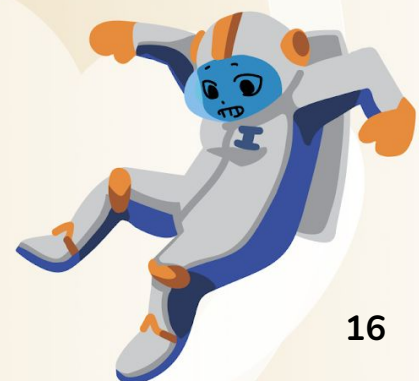
Project Showcase

HackIllinois' Project Showcase is akin to a science fair. You will have the opportunity to showcase your innovative projects to our esteemed judges!

Note: **ALL TEAMS** that have submitted a project will present **in-person** during the **Project Showcase**.

Format

1. Plan to arrive at the event location at least 15 minutes (8:45 AM) before the official start time so that we can go over the showcase format. **If you arrive over 10 minutes past the official start time, your project will be disqualified and removed from final consideration.**
2. Each team will receive your team number via email on **Sunday morning** so please be on the lookout.
3. During this 120-minute time period, you can present your projects to judges and receive feedback for your project. Please limit your presentation to 5 minutes:
 - a. You will have 3 minutes to present your project. After 3 minutes, we will ask you to wrap up your presentation within two sentences.
 - b. The judging panel may conduct a 2-minute Q&A session following the presentation.



Top 7 HackVoyagers Pitch

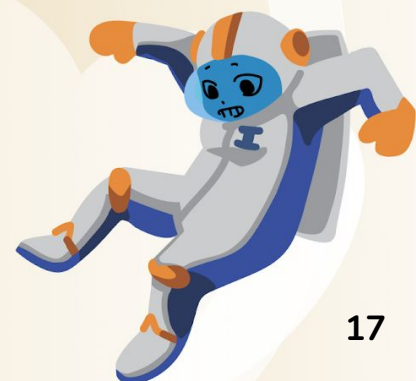
Inspired by the hit TV series Shark Tank, the Top 7 HackVoyagers Pitch is focused on promoting entrepreneurship in technology by having teams pitch their HackIllinois project to a panel of judges. Moreover, **in the past, our company sponsors have reached out to standout presenters to further invest in and develop their projects!**

Note: Teams selected to be a part of HackVoyagers Pitch will be notified by **11:30 AM Sunday, March 1st** via email.

Format

1. Lunch will be prepared in **Siebel 0216** for Top HackVoyager teams at 11:30 AM.
2. Plan to arrive at least 15 minutes before the official start time. However, you can arrive earlier for lunch.
3. At 12:00 PM, we will enforce a strict no-laptop, no-talking rule to ensure all teams have an equal amount of time prepare.
4. You will be given up to **12 minutes** to present to judges and receive feedback for your project.
 - a. You will have 7 minutes to pitch your project.
 - b. The judging panel will conduct a 5-minute Q&A session following the presentation.
5. Your presentation materials may include anything that can be projected and shared as a link. Still, keep in mind that time is limited and too many presentation materials will take up time!

Note: The HackVoyager Pitch will be closed to only selected teams and the judging panel. We WILL be livestreaming the showcase on [Youtube](#).



Top 7 HackVoyagers Pitch Details

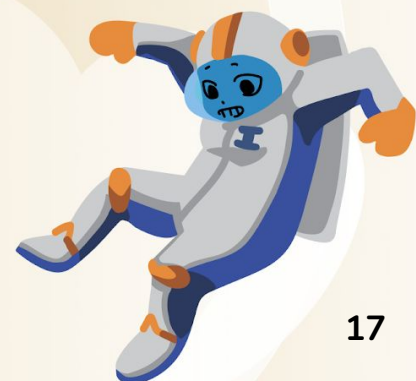
Attention Hackers!

The moment of truth is approaching. The **FulcrumGT HackVoyagers Pitch** is where your code meets the real world. We aren't just looking for a cool demo, we want to see a vision that can survive outside the hackathon bubble.

When you step onto that stage, stop thinking like a coder for a second and start thinking like a **Founder**. Your goal is to convince the "Sharks" that your project isn't just a weekend project.

The Recommended Pitch Deck: To give your team the best shot at "funding," ensure your pitch covers these core pillars:

- **Problem:** Define the pain point clearly. Why does it matter right now?
- **Solution:** What have you built, and what is your **Unique Selling Proposition**? Why is your way better than everything else?
- **Vision:** What is the "North Star" of your project? What big change are you trying to bring to the world?
- **Technical Implementation:** Show us the engine under the hood. How did you build it, and why is your tech stack the right choice for the job?
- **Market Opportunity:** How big is this? Show us the potential scale and the specific audience you are targeting.
- **Competitors:** Don't ignore them! Acknowledge who else is in the space and explain your "moat" i.e. what keeps them from doing what you do?
- **Business Model:** How does this make money or sustain itself? Even the best ideas need Benjamins.
- **Growth/Future:** What happens on Monday morning? Tell us your roadmap for scaling and future features.





Terms & Conditions

By registering for this event, you are agreeing to the HackIllinois & MLH [terms and conditions](#).

Thank you for your interest in our event! We look forward to seeing your projects, and happy coding!

Contact Information

If you have any questions, comments, or concerns during the event please feel free to reach out to us at contact@hackillinois.org, type @Help Desk in any of our Help Channels or create a ticket via Discord, or come to our in-person help desks at Siebel, located right outside of the ACM Office (1104)!

Thank You!

Thank you for taking the time to read through this guide. For more details and the official event schedule, please refer to the HackIllinois website [here](#). We hope you have an enjoyable time at HackIllinois 2026 and launch something stellar!

